

would have its version control system, and submissions of code or content to the version control system undergo the age-old process of peer review. How are these two important? It helps a student get familiar with the theory and practices of version control, the need to write code/content/patches according to established guidelines, and build upon the communication skills learnt to appreciate the feedback from a peer review group.

So, from just interested participants, willing students are well on the road to becoming well-rounded developers with various skills that make them invaluable when the recruiting season comes around. But wait, there's more: FOSS development processes ensure that contributions of code/content are always out in the open and available for perusal/analysis. What this means is a portfolio of development work. How does that help? Well, if there is an existing body of peer-reviewed code/content on a publicly-available version control system, it helps a recruiter do a technical assessment of the candidate. This does not really mean that a company would waive standard procedures of technical tests, but it would perhaps be of an added advantage when put in the perspective of peers. And, for companies already doing FOSS, such a code/content portfolio is of immense use. It allows them to form a judgement around the competencies of the candidate and even check out with the project module leads about how good the contributor is.

The curricula teaches the students about the Software Development Life Cycle (SDLC), its various stages, and the different checks and documentation that make up the Body of Knowledge. Participating in an upstream FOSS project provides an excellent exposure to these intricacies.

Following up a project roadmap and working on tasks related to modules/components, while keeping in mind the project release cycles, allows the contributor to become proficient in the real-life aspects of the SDLC concepts. Additionally, with time and an increase in the quantum of contributions, the new contributor would soon be confident enough to help out and mentor others in the project. Thus completing the circle, while learning how to work with dispersed teams, communicate virtually and work to timelines.

These are qualities that companies spend an inordinate amount of time inculcating in their new recruits; while participating in a FOSS model of software development, anyone can learn it as on-the-job training. This can be done in addition to the activities of an academic life. Lessons from books are somewhat easily tested and applied in real-life projects. Thus, students should take the time to look at any interesting project and make an effort to participate in it.

So, why did I say that FOSS will not get students a job? It should be fairly obvious by now. Brushing your teeth regularly does not automatically make you a film star, does it? But good dental hygiene along with disciplined practice should equip you with a pleasing personality that may (or, may not) lead to stardom. In somewhat a similar way, FOSS allows anyone to acquire skills and personality traits that lead towards becoming a better developer and an improved person—which is a long way down the road towards building a good career.



By: Sankarshan Mukhopadhyay

The author has been using Fedora since the days of Fedora Core 1. He can be reached at morpheus at fedoraproject dot org, or as sankarshan at jabber dot com on IM.

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